

Does news media regarding climate change have an effect on people's
behaviour in Egypt?

A focus group study

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Introduction

Global warming is a world problem. The potential solutions have to begin at a local level. In a country like Egypt, the effects of climate change may be even stronger than in other parts of the world – with temperatures during the summer reaching up to 50 degrees Celsius.

According to Ajaz (2023), climate change, poor water management, recurring droughts, and the new Ethiopian hydropower dam on the Nile River are worsening the water crisis in the country. Agriculture is vital to the Egyptian economy, accounting for approximately 14.5% of GDP. The agricultural sector utilizes the most water, accounting for more than 85% of Egypt's Nile water allocation (Seyd, 2023). According to UNICEF (2019), Egypt is facing an annual water deficit of around seven billion cubic meters. In addition, Egypt has a high population growth rate, so it is expected that the share of water per capita will decrease to 534 cubic metres by 2030, which is nearly half the international threshold for water poverty (Aziz, 2020). Therefore, it begins imperative to conserve on water. However, getting Egyptians to change their current behaviours may be difficult.

One study that looked at getting people to conserve on water was done by Dickerson et al (1992). The researchers carried out a field experiment on a university campus encouraging students to take shorter showers. They found that when people were both told that they had wasted water in the past and made a public commitment to change their behaviour, they were more likely to take shorter showers. If they simply were told about water wastage or they were simply asked if they would take shorter showers, there was no effect. This shows that changing behaviour is difficult, not just in Egypt, but also in the United States.

Cialdini et al (2008, cited in Hagan) wanted to see if they could encourage hotel guests to reuse their towels as a way of cutting down on laundry. Two different messages were left in hotel rooms with the goal of getting people to reuse their towels. In one condition, they were told of the importance of reusing their towels to save the environment. In the second message, the researchers used the "social norm appeal," telling the guests that the majority of guests reused their towels to save the environment. They found that when the second sign was used, 26% more guests reused their towels. Cialdini calls this approach a "nudge" and he argues that this would be a good method for governments to use.

Another problem in Egypt is that there is a lot of misinformation about climate change. According to the activist group Meedan (2023), the most read newspapers have the most misinformation, including political propaganda, highlighting alleged government achievements and policies such as solar power projects in rural areas of Egypt.

The aim of this study is to investigate the following question: Does news media regarding climate change have an effect on people's behaviour in Egypt?

Methodology

We decided to carry out focus groups with people in their late 20's and early 30s to see if the media played a role in their choice to save water or to recycle. Both of these behaviours are important in coping with climate change in Egypt. The focus groups would take place in Cairo at a local high school. To get a sample, we would ask parents at the local high school whether they would be willing to participate. This would be done by putting notices in the parent weekly bulletin for a period of three weeks. We would ask parents to contact us and then we would set up a time to have the interviews. The goal would be to have five different groups of eight participants. Two groups would be only male, two groups would be only female, and one group would be mixed. This would be done to make sure that we controlled for gender differences. It could also be important because Egyptian society is rather traditional, so in a mixed group women may not be as comfortable sharing their thoughts in front of a man. We would take the first 40 people who volunteered for our sample.

We would ask the participants to come to the school on a specific date at a specific time. They would sit in a circle with the other participants and the researcher would facilitate by reading a set of questions. The group would then discuss the questions (see appendix 1). The focus group would be video recorded so that the researcher would not be distracted by having to take notes while the interview was happening. The interview would start with a short movie film about climate change and the effect it is having on the Middle East. After the film was shown, the questions would be read. The focus group would last for 40 minutes. When it was over, the participants would be thanked and debriefed.

Just like in experiments, ethical considerations are important in focus groups. Every participant will be asked to sign a letter of consent (see appendix 1). Although it is unlikely that any of the questions would be traumatic or disturbing, they will also be told that they can withdraw at any time. The biggest difficulty in a focus group is that anonymity cannot be guaranteed. We will promise to destroy the film once we have finished collecting our data, but we cannot guarantee that other members of the focus group won't tell others what the participants said.

Data collection

When we collect the data, we will do this in focus groups. There will be five groups – two with only men, two with only women, and one mixed gender. All of the data will be confidential and the video will be destroyed after we complete the study.

It was decided that there needed to be some rules (norms) that the researcher would read to the group to make sure that the procedure went smoothly. An important norm is that they should not speak about what is said outside of the focus group. Another one is that everyone must respect other people's comments. If people don't feel respected, they won't speak in the group. We want to make sure that everyone has a voice in the group is heard.

To design the questions, I gave the questions to my teacher and to two other students to give feedback on the original draft. I decided to ask open-ended questions with the hope of getting a wider range of responses from the participants. I decided not to ask directly about the media because we did not want the participants to show demand characteristics.

When the interviews were complete, I will make a transcript of the interviews and then look for themes to see how both they and the government could play a role in fighting global warming, as well as how the media may play a role in changing people's perspectives.

Although I do not anticipate any challenges to collecting the data, there are always the unknowns. For example, the recording might not work or the quality might not be good. To prevent this, I will test the equipment each session to make sure that the quality is good. Perhaps the biggest concern is that people might not show up for the focus group. It is

important that all of the groups have the same size, so if people in one group do not show up for the interview, this could make our findings insignificant. Another problem might be in the mixed gender group. It could be that because there are people of both genders, the women will not feel that they can disagree with the men in the group. It could also be true that the men do not want to discuss their behaviour in front of the women. This group may then skew the results of the overall study.

Discussion

In spite of the fact that there will be some challenges, the findings of this study may help to make changes in Egyptian society. If we know that people feel that the media is helping them to better understand climate change – or it is giving them misinformation – then the government should do something to better monitor what is happening in the media. Having evidence based on not just one but five different focus groups is important for convincing the government to act. In addition to making some changes to the media, the government might also decide to make changes to schools. Currently, very few Egyptian schools offer courses where students can learn about climate change. If the government sees that there is a problem with the misinformation as a result of the focus groups, the government might decide to add required courses in environmental awareness as part of the required education. Finally, we might find out that Egyptians actually do a lot to protect the environment. This would be very good news, but we have to remember that we have a limited sample of people. The people in this sample are all from a private international school in Cairo and, therefore, do not represent the larger Egyptian population.

There are several potential biases that could influence the study. First, participants might have personal biases that influence their responses. They may be pro-environmental or they could be for a specific party in the government. This could influence what they are willing to say in the focus group. In addition, there could be gender bias. We are hoping to control for gender biases by having two groups be only males, two groups be only females, and one group be mixed gender. It could be that women are more aware of global warming than men are. Finally, there could be cultural biases. In this study, we expect that all of the parents that volunteer to be part of the study would be Egyptian. Anyone that is not Egyptian would

have to be excluded from the sample. As Egyptians, they could be biased because global warming is having a very direct influence on their lives. There could also be the bias that men would not listen to the women's voices in the group. Egyptian culture also shows respect for the oldest men. This could be a problem in the groups because then the oldest man may influence the group too much since the other men would not feel that they could contradict him.

If we were going to expand this study and use another research method, I would use an experimental study. Only with a true experiment can you determine cause and effect. I would have one group watch a film about climate change and another group watch a film about climate denial. And then, a week later, I would have them come back and ask them questions about their behaviour in the last week. This would include their average shower time, if they have recycled this week, and whether they believe that they can make a difference. This would be useful because it could be replicated to determine its reliability. It would also have high internal validity because it would be done in a laboratory. Finally, unlike a focus group, we would not have the ethical problem that other people would break confidentiality and talk to other people about what the participants said or did.

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Appendix 1: Letter of consent

The goal of this focus group is to discuss ways that we can make a difference when it comes to global warming. We would like to thank you for agreeing to be part of our study.

As part of our study, we would like to interview you as part of a focus group of eight people. The whole interview will last no more than 40 minutes. The focus group interview must be recorded so that we can transcribe the findings later. However, we will not use the recording except to analyse the data. When the interview is over, the film will be destroyed.

Your comments will be kept anonymous. However, we cannot guarantee that your information will be private since other people in the group may talk to others about it. So, we ask that you also not talk about this with people outside of the group.

You have the right to withdraw from the study if for any reason you do not wish to continue. In addition, you will be informed of the findings of the study after its completion.

Name _____

Date _____

Signature _____

Appendix 2: Focus group interview guide

Introductions: The researcher will introduce herself and explain the purpose of the focus group.

The purpose of this focus group is to discuss how your life has been influenced by global warming and how you might change your behaviour.

Each participant will then share their name and what they do for a living.

We then will read the norms for the focus group:

- Each person should speak for yourself
- Every person's comments are valued.
- Confidentiality is important.
- Only one person speaks at a time.

We then would ask permission to record the session and pass out the letter of consent.

Questions:

1. Do you consider yourself "environmentally aware?" Why or why not?
2. What have you done in the last month to save water either at work or at home?
3. Do you think that you could do more to save water? Why or why not?
4. Do you recycle? If so, what do you recycle?
5. Do you think that the government could do more to help the fight against climate change?

After all questions are asked, the group would be thanked and debriefed.